Indian cricket.

On top of that, the IPL (Indian Premier League) has become a juggernaut and must be commended. Simply put, the IPL is phenomenal. When a nineteen-year-old rookie plays alongside Shane Warne or Glenn McGrath or Chris Gayle or AB de Villiers, and then goes back and plays for his college team or local club, can you imagine what incredible things it does for him and his confidence? Can you imagine what sharing the dressing room or the dug-out with such global cricketing heroes does to a youngster in the game? Can you imagine how he learns from the way they play, train, eat, sleep and party?

The IPL has exposed India's youngsters to the best in the world. It is because of such exposure that there is going to be no pressure on them if and when they enter the national team. That's a major achievement because, for a young player, pressure is the real enemy, not the opposition he is playing against. On top of that, of course, Indian youngsters have received so many chances and platforms to perform at the IPL that a whole new range and generation of talent and skill sets has emerged.

Add to that India's cricket academies and sports facilities, which are now almost at par with the best in the world and designed to meet the modern cricketer's needs, and you've got yourself a rival who will keep on improving consistently. If Pakistan is serious about maintaining this rivalry and dominating over India on the cricket field again, the PCB should take note.

Our comfort zone when touring in India has shifted too. Earlier, it wasn't like that. On previous tours, I remember we used to shop, loiter around and explore like it were our own country. Such adventures have stopped now.

As for the Indian players and our relationship with them, things have evolved. There is no mercy for India on the field, of course. Off the field, we were close. Great friends, some of us. But of late, politics has seeped in everywhere.

Look at Virender Sehwag. Look at the negative statements he makes on Twitter about Pakistan. Is that responsible behaviour? Consider his fans all over the world. Consider his fans here, in Pakistan. I try to stay positive. So does Virat Kohli; he's been great. But after the recent air battles between India and Pakistan post the Pulwama attacks and the Balakot bombings, and the Indian team going all gung-ho and camo with its caps, on the field … That was a bit much. See, we are not politicians. We are ambassadors. We can't be partisan, except on the field. In this new, hyper India, Kohli, Sehwag and Co. clearly don't get that.

Things are lukewarm, at best, now. Back in the day, we would even have each other over for a meal. During Mohammad Azharuddin's captaincy, I once had the whole Indian team over for dinner. We even went out and partied together. Now, we just pop into each other's rooms, if that's possible at all. The curfews don't help. The anti-corruption lockdowns don't help. The lack of cricket doesn't help.

Rivalries are natural in sport. But with India, they're instinctual. And with the media hype, they're accentuated further.

In my heyday, the rivalry with Irfan Pathan was instinctive. There can only be one Pathan on the field. In a jungle, there's one lion. The other one is a lioness, or perhaps, a cub.

There were healthy rivalries, too. Virat. Yuvi. Bhajji. Zaheer. We evened things out by hanging out and chilling together post-match. But in the last four or five years, as relations between the two countries soured politically, things got very edgy.